

Left and Right before Left and Right: 250 Years of Polarization in the United States

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Speaking at the 2004 Democratic Party convention, then Illinois state senator Obama remarked: “...there are those who are preparing to divide us, the spin masters and negative ad peddlers who embrace the politics of anything goes. Well, I say to them tonight, there’s not a liberal America and a conservative America — there’s the United States of America.” This quote captures a widespread and longstanding view that American political elites, and Americans themselves, are not truly ideologically polarized. Instead, divisive political conflicts are manufactured by the media, activists, pundits, opportunistic politicians, and so on. Some writers go so far as to claim the left-right, liberal-conservative ideological spectrum is a “myth.” In this account, ideological conflict is entirely a pre-textual language for partisan tribal warfare.¹ Indeed, the notion of a left-right political spectrum derives from the French revolution and likely did not acclimate into American politics until the early 20th century.

Is ideological thinking and the imported left-right metaphor to blame for the polarization of contemporary politics?

No. In this essay, I describe a *spatial* view of American politics and apply it to Congressional roll call votes going back to the very first Congress. This perspective provides a useful model of political conflict before the left-right metaphor was commonplace in America. In my account, polarization of political ideology in a simple, low-dimensional space (i.e., one or two ideological dimensions) is an emergent epiphenomena of America’s democratic institutions at a very fundamental level, not a historical accident that can be undone. This is not to say that the liberal-to-conservative spectrum as it is defined today spans across all of time and space, or that elite polarization is constant over American history. To be sure, the substantive content of political conflict changes dynamically over time.² Issues, factions, even whole political parties come and go, but a low dimensional representation of political conflict is always in view. The nature and extent of political conflict is the question, not whether that conflict exists or is describable in the first place.

Politics in Space

What is the “spatial” view of politics? The spatial model³ assumes that politicians and voters exist along a low dimensional, usually one-dimensional, ideological spectrum and have an ideal position along that spectrum. This single dimension encompasses the “issue space” of conflict. Of course, this is a reductionist way of viewing politics. Should free speech be an absolute right, or a constrained privilege? Should retirees receive more public benefits or less? Should transgender athletes compete in sports aligning with their birth sex? Somehow, voters

1 Hyrum Lewis and Verlan Lewis, *The Myth of Left and Right: How the Political Spectrum Misleads and Harms America* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2023).

2 Edward G. Carmines and James A. Stimson, *Issue Evolution: Race and the Transformation of American Politics* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1989).

3 Anthony Downs, *An Economic Theory of Democracy* (New York: Harper & Row, 1957); Melvin J. Hinich and Michael C. Munger, *Ideology and the Theory of Political Choice* (University of Michigan Press, 1994).

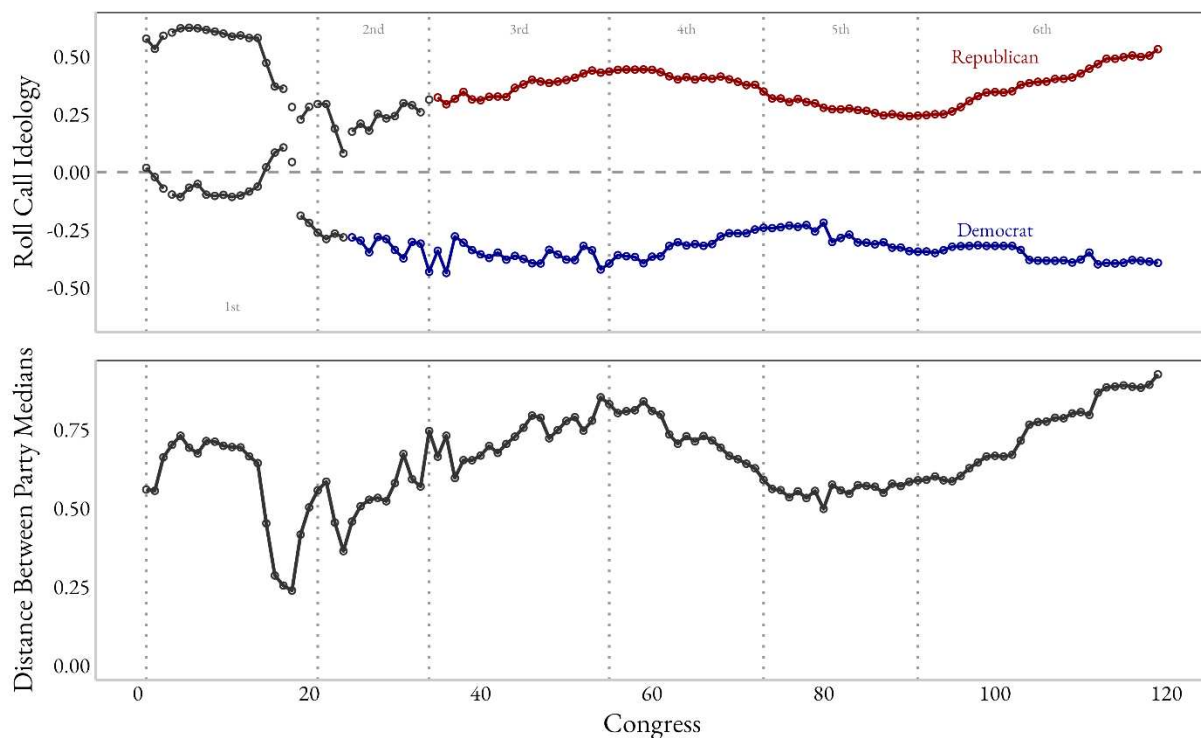
and elites are supposed to come to views about issues as broad and diverse as these, and in our era of extreme conflict extension, literally dozens or even hundreds more. Compression and simplification are, in the spatial view, unavoidable.

Roll Call Polarization in Congress: 1789-2026

To measure where members of Congress exist in ideological space, political scientists attempt to estimate ideological ideal points (i.e., where on the left-right spectrum a member sits based on their votes). This is a complicated exercise, but for the sake of this essay, it's sufficient to think of this process as a projection: we take all of the votes a member of Congress takes on all legislation, compare those votes with other members of Congress, and compress all of that information down into one point estimate for where they sit *relative* to other members on a left-right spectrum.

The figure below presents the median ideal point estimate for members of the majority political parties going back to the first Congress, as well as a simple measure of polarization in the House: the simple difference between the median ideal point of the median member of the leftward and rightward party.

250 Years of Polarization in the U.S. House



Note: Red and blue lines represent Republican and Democratic party medians respectively, other dots represent the median member of the left or right major party that existed at the time. Vertical dotted lines correspond to the period of party systems from the first through

the sixth. Roll call votes DW-NOMINATE scores are sourced from Voteview Congressional database.⁴

From this picture, the first thing to notice is the extremity of modern polarization. Indeed, as others have noted, ideological polarization on Congressional roll call votes has reached a historic fever pitch.⁵ Nonetheless, across the sweep of American history the major parties, or in the early Republic mere factions, are always differentiable from one another and often quite polarized. That is to say, there is always some underlying, low dimensional conflict that is present in roll call votes.⁶

Conflict Extension and Issue Evolution

Over time, policy issues rise and fall as the two parties strategically adopt positions on these new topics to signal their views to voters. For example, for most of American history same sex marriage was illegal, and was not an issue that structured political conflict. However, as the issue became more contested on the political left and inside of one political faction - the 1990s Democratic party - Republican party elites noticed and adopted strong positions on the issue.⁷ Subsequently, the Democratic party evolved to be a pro-gay marriage party. This is an example of *conflict extension*,⁸ when a new policy issue enters the core ideological conflict that structures American political life. In the case of same sex marriage, the issue was, for a time, extremely polarizing both in Congress as well as in public opinion data. However, since the 2015 Supreme

4 Jeffrey B. Lewis et al., *Voteview: Congressional Roll-Call Votes Database* (2025), <https://voteview.com>.

5 According to these estimates, recent polarization is somewhat asymmetric, with the Republican party moving further right than the Democratic party has moved left. Whether congressional polarization is truly asymmetric remains contested; see Nolan McCarty, *Polarization: What Everyone Needs to Know* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2019); and Nathan Canen, Chad Kendall, and Francesco Trebbi, “Unbundling Polarization,” *Econometrica* 88, no. 3 (2020): 1197–1233.

6 A crucial distinction that is too often glazed over is polarization among *who*? Ordinary people or political elites? For political elites—in particular members of Congress but other elites as well—there is consensus among scholars that polarization is extreme even by historical standards. Whether this polarization is symmetrical, i.e., the median Democrat has moved as far to the left as the median Republican has moved to the right, or not is contested, but the mere fact of increased polarization is indisputable and not dependent on a single source of information (e.g., rollcall votes, campaign contributions, political speeches, etc.) or measurement technique (e.g., scaling methods such as NOMINATE, Bonica’s DIME scores, Barbera’s social media scaling, etc.). On the other hand, scholars disagree fiercely over polarization in the mass public. A popular view that is sometimes referred to as “democratic realist” (popular among political elites) views voters as myopic, uninformed, retrospective, even plainly dumb. On the other hand, there is a spatial view of voters that operates much like the spatial view of elites. This way of thinking is intuitively rooted in left-right, directional thinking. A popular recent account tries to bridge these warring factions by proposing the electorate is a composite of spatial voters, (charitably) disengaged citizens, and idiosyncratic types. In this account, most voters are ideological in the left-right sense but hold relatively moderate policy positions, but there is still room in the electorate for voters who hold policy beliefs that “don’t go together” in a manner that comports with the spatial view. For example, a voter who is simultaneously pro-life, anti-second Amendment, pro-tax, and also deficit hawk. On alternative measures see Adam Bonica, “Mapping the Ideological Marketplace,” *American Journal of Political Science* 58, no. 2 (2014): 367–386 (DIME scores); and Pablo Barberá, “Birds of the Same Feather Tweet Together: Bayesian Ideal Point Estimation Using Twitter Data,” *Political Analysis* 23, no. 1 (2015): 76–91.

7 D. Sunshine Hillygus and Todd G. Shields, *The Persuadable Voter: Wedge Issues in Presidential Campaigns* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 2008).

8 Geoffrey C. Layman and Thomas M. Carsey, “Party Polarization and Conflict Extension in the American Electorate,” *American Journal of Political Science* 46, no. 4 (2002): 786–802.

Court decision, and the subsequent legalization of same sex marriage in all fifty states, the issue has broadly depolarized and new social issues (e.g., transgender participation in sports) have risen to take its place.

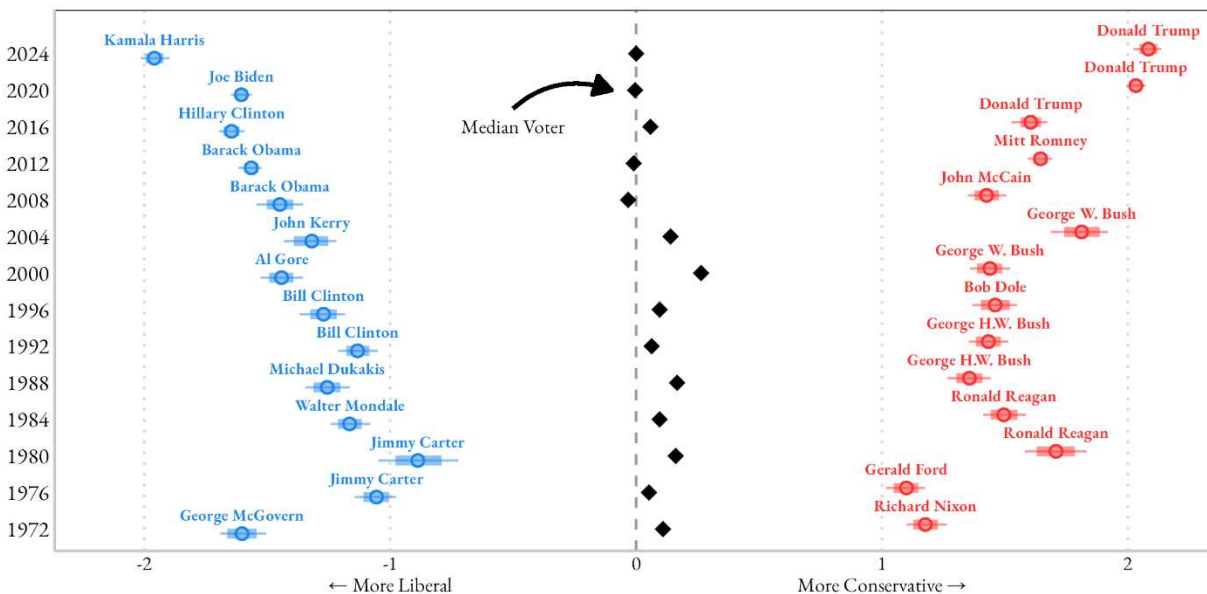
Conflict extension, like polarization, is not necessarily a bad thing. However, in recent years conflict has extended beyond policy to issues of fundamental concern: the rule of law and the legitimacy of election results. Moreover, partisans now openly debate sweeping, unilateral institutional changes. This is certainly a reason to be concerned. Polarization of elite opinion on these topics is unlikely to yield policy improvement or bipartisan consensus, but could escalate political conflict in unforeseen ways.

A Picture of Recent Presidential Polarization

Scholars agree Congress has polarized in recent decades. But what about Presidential candidates? Unfortunately, Presidential candidates do not take thousands of roll call votes that allow us to place them in ideological space. While candidates do typically commit to dozens of issue positions, e.g. I will not sign a national abortion ban, these are mere statements that candidates often back out on. Quantifying the ideology of Presidential candidates directly through their policy positions is difficult, however, it is possible to measure the *mass perception* of Presidential ideology. Going back to the early 1970s, the American National Election Study has asked Americans to place themselves, as well as candidates for the Presidency on a scale from liberal to conservative. Using a statistical technique,⁹ we can use their answers to paint a picture of perceived Presidential ideology relative to the median voter going back to the 1972 Presidential election.

⁹ John H. Aldrich and Richard D. McKelvey, “A Method of Scaling with Applications to the 1968 and 1972 Presidential Elections,” *American Political Science Review* 71, no. 1 (1977): 111–130; Christopher Hare et al., “Using Bayesian Aldrich-McKelvey Scaling to Study Citizens’ Ideological Preferences and Perceptions,” *American Journal of Political Science* 59, no. 3 (2015): 759–774; Jørgen Bølstad, “Hierarchical Bayesian Aldrich-McKelvey Scaling,” *Political Analysis* 32, no. 1 (2024): 50–64.

Presidential Ideology as Perceived by the Mass Public



Note: Blue dots represent Democratic candidates for President, red dots represent Republican candidates, and black dots represent the median voter in each election. 95% and 99% credible intervals are displayed around point estimates for ideology. The data is sourced from the American National Election Surveys, the technique employed to estimate ideology is hierarchical Bayesian Aldrich-McKelvey Scaling estimated using the hbamr R package.¹⁰

The perception of ideological divergence between major party candidates is striking. Over time, voters perceive Presidential candidates as increasingly ideologically extreme, with candidates in recent elections being the most extreme of all. The median voter is twice as far from President Trump or Vice President Harris relative to Presidents Carter and Ford. While the divergence in perceived presidential ideology does not necessarily reflect “true” changes in the latent ideology of presidential candidates — the voters could be incorrect in their evaluations — at the very least voters *perceive* presidential candidates as increasingly extreme. Even before the modern era, voters perceived major party candidates as being ideologically distinct in left-right terms, and often quite distal from one another.

Conflict Resolution?

Conflict and polarization among American political elites, in American political institutions, and even among the mass public, are a dynamic but consistent feature of the republic going back to the very beginning. This conflict is visible in Congress before formal political parties came to be and before the left-right metaphor entered political consciousness. While polarization is certainly worse today on America’s 250th birthday than it has been in recent decades, the phenomena of spatial conflict, and polarization among elites, is not new. The important question is not whether polarization is good or bad.

¹⁰ Estimates computed with the hbamr R package; see Bølstad, “Hierarchical Bayesian Aldrich-McKelvey Scaling.” Figure is associated with Rametta, Fuller, and Algara, “Symbolic and Operational Ideology: Evidence from U.S. Presidential Elections 1972–2024.” Working paper, 2025.

Instead, we should concern ourselves with what exactly the parties are polarized over, and how divisions might be resolved. In the past, polarization in Congress has resolved through a wide variety of mechanisms: wars, recessions, decisive electoral results, new social movements, etc. It is impossible to predict when, or if, the current polarization will subside. Whatever else one thinks, the extension of political conflict into basic questions of the rule of law should worry us all.